



WATCH THE
INTERVIEW

« Frequent regime changes in PCB have hurt Pakistan cricket badly »

SAEED AJMAL

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

Until recently, Saeed Ajmal was Pakistan's spin-bowling coach. A few months ago, he was relieved of his duties. Now, he spends his time coaching local teams and working with Islamabad United in the Pakistan Super League.

Despite being out of the national setup, Ajmal closely follows Pakistan cricket and was disappointed with the team's performance in the Champions Trophy at home. However, he warns against knee-jerk reactions. He believes frequent leadership changes at the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) have hurt the team's progress. He is also unhappy with how the selectors have handled Babar Azam and Mohammad Rizwan ahead of the New Zealand series.

In a chat with *Sportstar*, Ajmal shares his views on Pakistan cricket and why the country struggles to produce quality spinners despite its rich history.

Pakistan hosted a global tournament after nearly 30 years but failed to reach the knockouts. What went wrong?

It was very disappointing for us. Of course, it was a matter of pride that Pakistan was hosting a global

event after 30 years. Throughout my career, I didn't play any ICC event at home, despite making my debut against India in the 2008 Asia Cup.

So, this time around, it was disappointing to see the Pakistan team out of the Champions Trophy in the first round. The team did not give a good performance. Adding to that, there was no final in Pakistan, despite us hosting. As a fan, as an ex-cricketer, as a Pakistani, I would have liked the final to be played at home. Just as Indian fans don't want their team to play outside India, we also wanted to watch India and Pakistan play at home.

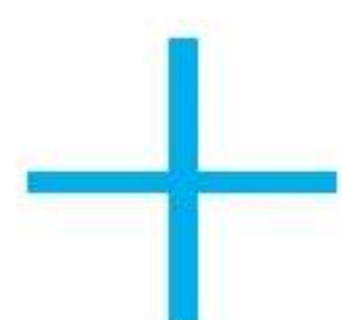
I have always believed that sports should be kept out of politics. We are sportsmen. Sportsmen represent love and affection for each other. Off the field, we are friends. I know it was decided much in advance that India wouldn't travel to Pakistan, but

we still regret not having all the matches at home. It would have been a lot of fun.

Despite home conditions, Pakistan went with just one spinner in the Champions Trophy. Does this reflect a lack of quality spinners?

Even teams like New Zealand and Australia played with three spinners, but I don't know if we misjudged the conditions or if our calculations were wrong. It was our home, and we could have played at any venue of our choice, but we misjudged the conditions and were caught in the middle. We neither produced a spin-friendly surface nor a pace-friendly strip, and we got caught there.

There were issues with our team selection. Why did we not play another spinner? Why did we not pick the right players? If you look at



The rise of league cricket has done a lot of harm to us. The players who are coming in want to play league cricket for four days, earn money, have fun, and move on.